Pickleball Self-Rating Guide With Measurable Criteria

To rate yourself, choose the level where you meet most of the measurable criteria (80–90% of listed points).

Beginner

You are likely here if MOST of the following are true:

- ☐ Serve lands in **50–70%** of attempts.
- ☐ Return of serve successful **50–70%** of the time.
- ☐ Rally length typically **1–4 shots**.
- ☐ Still learning rules (kitchen, double bounce, scoring).
- ☐ Often hits balls **too high**, **into net**, or **out**.
- ☐ Footwork is reactive; rarely reaches the NVZ consistently.
- ☐ Relies mostly on forehand; backhand is weak or avoided.
- ☐ Unforced errors: **10+ per game**.

If you can't consistently complete rallies yet → you're a Beginner

Improver

You fit here if you can measure most of the following:

- ☐ Serve lands **75–85%** of attempts.
- ☐ Return of serve successful **75–85%**.
- ☐ Rally length commonly **4–8 shots**.
- ☐ Gets to the NVZ sometimes, but not consistently under pressure.
- ☐ Can dink, but dinks are often **too high / inconsistent**.
- ☐ Attempts third shot drops but only **successful ~30–40%**.
- ☐ Can volley but lacks directional control.
- ☐ Understands rules and general positioning.
- ☐ Unforced errors: **7–10 per game**.

If you can play, but consistency is still the main issue → you're an Improver

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Intermediate

You are likely an Intermediate if measurable play looks like this:

- ☐ Serve successful **90%+** with reasonable depth.
- ☐ Return of serve **90%+**, usually past the NVZ line.
- ☐ Rally length commonly **8+ shots**.
- ☐ Gets to the NVZ **most points** when possible.
- ☐ Dinks are controlled **60–70%** of the time.
- ☐ Third shot drop works **40–60%** of attempts.
- ☐ Can reset occasionally but struggles under pressure.
- ☐ Beginning to place shots toward opponents' weaknesses.
- ☐ Unforced errors: **5–7 per game**.

If you're consistent, understand strategy, but execution varies you're an Intermediate

High Intermediate

You fit this level when most of these are true:

- ☐ Serve and return **>95%** and intentionally placed.
- ☐ **Routinely reaches and plays confidently at the NVZ.**
- ☐ **Can sustain dink rallies of 10–20+ balls.**
- ☐ **Third-shot drop success 60–75%.**
- ☐ **Effective mix of drops, drives, and lobs (chosen with purpose).**
- ☐ **Reads attacks and can block/reset into the kitchen regularly.**
- ☐ Wins many points through patience rather than luck.
- ☐ Controls pace instead of reacting.
- ☐ Unforced errors: **3–5 per game**.

If you're reliable, strategic and competitive in strong open play you're at this level.

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Advanced

You are likely here if these are consistently true:

- ☐ Serves and returns are **deep, purposeful, and >98%** consistent.
- ☐ Strong footwork; reaches NVZ early and maintains control.
- ☐ Dinking is strategic: varies **height, depth, angle, speed**.
- ☐ Third-shot drop success **75–90%**, including under pressure.
- ☐ Transition game is strong: resets, blocks, counters with intent.
- ☐ Frequently initiates and wins hand-speed battles.
- ☐ Anticipates instead of reacting; reads patterns quickly.
- ☐ Communication and court coverage with partner are excellent.
- ☐ Unforced errors: **0–3 per game** while still playing aggressively.

If you *control* points rather than simply participate you're at the Advanced level

Quick Self-Test Checklist

Try these in real play or practice:

Skill Test	Beginner	Improver	Intermediate	High Int	Advanced
Serve in 20 attempts	≤14	15–17	18–19	19–20	20
Returns deep (past NVZ) out of 20	≤10	11–14	15–17	18–19	19–20
Consistent dink rally count	≤5	6–10	10–15	15–25	25+
Third-shot drop success (20 tries)	≤6	7–9	10–12	13–15	16–18
Avg. unforced errors per game	10+	7–10	5–7	3–5	0–3

How to Choose Your Level

1. Play normally
2. Track the measurable points over 2–3 games
3. Rate yourself at the level where you match **most** metrics
4. If split between levels → choose the lower one for fairness.

Credit: Adapted from Dink Pickleball